FRG contacts have little hope or expectation that East Germany will respond any further to the West German request.

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The US brief was correct, the GDR – which had no major drug problem – displayed no interest in attempting to apprehend couriers. Furthermore, those same couriers had no desire to sell drugs for non-convertible DDM and did not linger in East Berlin. They presented no threat to GDR security, health, or morals, and contributed to the economy by purchasing Interflug tickets with hard currency. Some suspected that the GDR disinterest was also sustained by a desire not to do anything which might alleviate a serious West Berlin social problem – at least not with exacting a high price.

By the late 70s, it was calculated that there were around 6,000 drug addicts in West Berlin, many would gather in the Zoo and the Kurfürstendamm underground stations waiting to buy their ‘fix’ of heroin.7

Meanwhile, as the glow of Montreal Olympic triumphs faded, Honecker found distraction in a pet building project opposite the Berlin Cathedral at the lower end of Unter den Linden, a street that traded on its illustrious past. At the site of the old Hohenzollern palace, he oversaw the development of the new ‘Palace of the Republic’, a vast glass and steel structure housing a 5,000-seat congress hall, theatre, disco, art gallery and sauna-gymnasium. All that splendour wasn’t cheap, with the government pouring more than US$300million into it, along with the wage bill for 3,100 workers and conscripts labouring on the site. Flooded with sunlight on clear days, the palace was full of jawdropping vistas from windows facing out to the neo-Baroque cathedral across the street and the vast television tower.

Illuminated by hundreds of lamps, the ornate ground level floor was crafted from marble imported from Karelia and Yugoslavia. ‘Here,’ noted the Berliner Zeitung, ‘visitors can find numerous facilities such as a post office, telephones, newspapers and bookstores as well as souvenir shops.’8 The